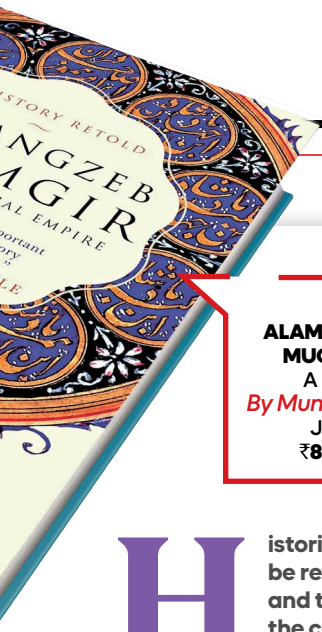


AURANGZEB ALAMGIR AND THE MUGHAL EMPIRE
A History Retold
By Munis D. Faruqui
JUGGERNAUT
₹**899; 416** pages

Historians like to be revisionists, and the stronger the conventional wisdom being challenged, the higher a work of history is regarded. Munis D. Faruqui challenges deeply ingrained notions about the most reviled of the great Mughals. His aim is to dislodge the prevalent view of Aurangzeb, or Alamgir (his regnal name) as Faruqui prefers calling him, as a hopeless bigot. His alternative thesis is that Alamgir "drew on Islam-inspired solutions to run the Mughal empire not because he aimed at wholesale conversion or religious cleansing of non-Muslims", but because he believed integrating Islamic values would "benefit all his subjects".

Faruqui's treatment is not a conventional biography and instead focuses on three broad themes. The first is largely a reassessment of Alamgir's career. The second, easily the best part, analyses the roles played by the Mughal harem and the eunuchs, breaking new ground and offering new insights into the most opaque aspect of Mughal polity—personal relationships; royal women's role as peacemakers; eunuchs as managers, diplomats and trusted intermediaries. These two chapters make this book outstanding. The third section examines Alamgir's last days to extract broader trends about a decaying empire and how views of Alamgir evolved after his death.

Faruqui's thesis is that Alamgir was "not trying to impose Islam on the empire so much as using an Islamic influenced moral vision to save a faltering empire". Here, the arguments are less convincing and Faruqui does not substantively address the obvious question of whether an "Islam-tinged sovereignty", as he terms it, was seen as exclusionary by increasingly powerful Hindu groups. In this regard, the comparisons with Akbar or even Ibrahim Adil Shah II of Bijapur are inevitable and should have been tackled head on.

Jadunath Sarkar's phantom stalks the first and third parts of this book, yet there are some notable near absences and silences, in particular Shivaji and his part in the drama of Alamgir's life. The Marathas, too, appear in a focused fashion only in the emperor's last days. Faruqui agrees that Alamgir's failure was most evident here and that other "connections that might have tied the Maratha chiefs to the Mughals—religious, linguistic or sociocultural links—were tenuous at best". Alamgir, he notes, never offered matrimonial alliances as Akbar had to the Rajputs. Faruqui does not, however, probe this nor the significant contrast with Akbar thereafter; this issue again limits one's appreciation for what is otherwise a fine piece of scholarship. ■

—T.C.A. Raghavan

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Thailand, Afghanistan, Ceylon and Singapore, to enthral audiences.

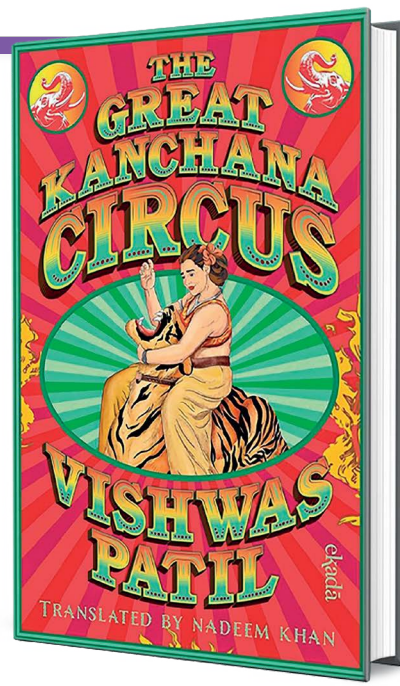
Vishwas Patil's novel *The Great Kanchana Circus*, translated by Nadeem Khan from Marathi, recreates this world, blending research with imagination. Drawing on personal interviews with circus owners, artistes and animal trainers, here is an engaging work of historical fiction set during World War II. At the heart of this story is a feisty woman named Kanchana, who owns an Indian circus stranded in British-ruled Burma, where bombs from Japanese fighter planes cover the earth with dead bodies lying "like leaves on an autumn lawn".

Her valiant efforts to bring her employees and her animals back to India forms the nucleus of this book, shedding light on a slice of Indian history that many contemporary readers are likely to be unfamiliar with. Patil's empathetic prose and Khan's skilful translation give us a moving portrait of Kanchana, a childless mother who thinks of the animals as her own babies.

Kanchana's entrepreneurial spirit makes her an object of envy. It is shocking to witness how badly her competitors want her to fail. To make matters worse, a government notice in Burma orders her circus to "dispatch all its animals outside the city limits of Rangoon" within 18 hours.

Read this book to find out what happens as Kanchana struggles with the challenges that life throws at her, including the prospect of losing Raghav, the man she loves with all her heart. ■

—Chintan Girish Modi



THE GREAT KANCHANA CIRCUS
By Vishwas Patil
WESTLAND/EKADA
₹**599; 392** pages